COMING HOME

He came in on the four o'clock flight.
We all went to meet his plane.
That night friends and family gathered.
We sipped iced tea
Its bitterness laced with the cloying sweet scent
Of too many roses.

And all the while
Dad sat silently near the window
Now and then he would reach out to pat
The flag-draped coffin that contained
Dog tags
And shattered dreams.

2007 First Place, Adult General